reluctant to pay their taxes.

There would be further conquests, too. Northwards and west, from Srinagar to Sindh; east, all the way to Cuttack, ‘at the end of the country and on the seashore’.[5] In the last years of his life, Akbar would even descend upon the Deccan, and begin the campaign that would eventually consume his dynasty.

In some ways, then, the second quarter-century of Akbar’s reign followed the pattern of the first: a steady, unrelenting expansion of the realm, a clear focus on the generation of wealth, and an equally resolute suppression of any opposition to the emperor. In other ways, however, Akbar’s second innings has a palpably different quality to it.

In March 1582, for example, four months after his triumphant return from Kabul, Akbar sent out ‘for all sorts of troops of singers and musicians both Hindu and Persian, and dancers, both men and women by thousands of thousands’[6] and celebrated Nauroz – a Zoroastrian festival that inaugurates the spring and the Persian new year. Akbar would use it to mark the start of every year of his reign. He had at least two good reasons to choose Nauroz as the festival of his rule: one, he inherited Humayun’s throne in February, shortly before this March festival. And two, Nauroz heralds the spring equinox, one of two days in the year on which the sun is aligned with the earth’s equator – in much the same way as light (of the sun, of fire, of the blaze in Alanqoa’s womb) was explicitly aligned with Akbar and his descendants’ imperial image.

‘A special grace,’ Akbar declared in one of his Happy Sayings, ‘proceeds from the sun in favour of kings, and for this reason they pray and consider it a worship of the Almighty; but the short-sighted are thereby scandalised.’[7] Whatever little hesitation Akbar might have had about scandalizing men – by reading the khutba, debating religions, wearing rakhis – that hesitation had been magicked away, much like the rain clouds that Akbar once dispersed with his breath. As Abul Fazl puts it, Akbar had long wanted to celebrate Nauroz but had refrained on account of the ‘general ignorance’ in his court, and courtiers ‘enchained in bigotry’. But now, in 1582, now that Akbar had ruled an astonishing twenty-six years and vanquished every challenge thrown at him, from the sudden death of his father to the control of his regents, the resentments of his warlords and clergy to the ambitions